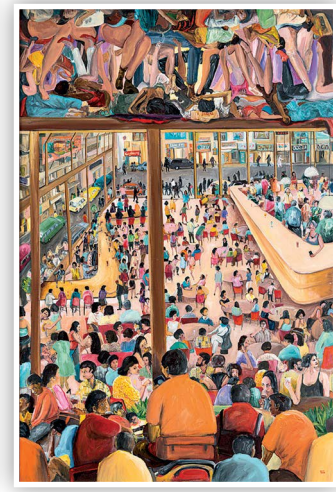


THE CHAOS WITHIN
'While There is Still Time'; (below) 'The Gig'



CHATTERJEE & LAL

EXHIBITION

The Middle PATH

Nityan Unnikrishnan's latest solo show at Chatterjee & Lal, Mumbai, is a depiction of our attempt to cope with the crumbling realities of our lives

The buzzer at Chatterjee & Lal lets you into a rarefied world. One populated by people in paintings who are seemingly like us but where you can glimpse their inner universe through rips in the fabric of the mind and heart. This is Nityan Unnikrishnan's exhibition titled *Man in the Middle*.

The artist confides that most of the 11 artworks on show, except one or two, were made over the past year and a half. "What brings the works together is that I made them at this point in life, which is a very good time of life—middle age—when you pack and unpack things and you suddenly start to get a sense of the end for the first time. And so, the *Man in the Middle*," explains Nityan, who has been showing his work at Chatterjee & Lal since the early days of his artistic career in 2010 (when he expanded his repertoire from furniture design to painting and sculpting).

Nityan says he made most of the 11 artworks on show at Man in the Middle over the past year and a half

This latest solo show gives us more of his evocative perspective on emotions. It's his depiction of our attempt to cope with the crumbling realities of our lives, be it through imagined escape or by hanging onto the last vestiges of social constructs.

On the surface, it's all about striking colours, bold brush strokes, and delicious detail. The vivid blues of 'While There is Still Time' and the vibrant class chaos of 'The Gig' catch the eye right off. But as you muse over each one, deeper insights reveal themselves, often disturbing, always thought-provoking.

While art is subjective and different paintings speak differently to different people, the one that's most arresting in this collection is undoubtedly 'The Other Room'. A woman plays the tanpura facing a mirror. Her closed eyes give the impression of serenity and absorption. But the maelstrom of memories that hovers at the edge of her conscious belies that, while a neatly packed suitcase hints at an escape, a stepping away from this room into another life.

Some, like 'Together', can hit you hard with hollowness and grief if you've been in the situation. In this case, at the bedside of an ailing loved one. The brightly hued room and pleasant accoutrements aren't able to draw your eye away from the woman's hunched shoulders and the stark emptiness of the medical bed she faces. Does her resigned posture indicate sorrow at the loss or relief at the end of the absent person's misery, or a mix of both?

Nityan never presumes to give you the answer. He presents the picture, and it's your emotional reaction to each that takes you on an individualistic artistic journey. Much like a writer, he's merely the man in the middle between his characters and your imagination. ■

–Priya Pathiyan

On view at Chatterjee & Lal, Colaba, Mumbai, ***Tuesdays to Saturdays (noon to 5 pm) until Dec. 21***